

Research Report

Senior Citizen Banking

Phase 1



by **Rhитуja Shende, Sandeep Kumar**

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About Qualitative Research

Qualitative research (like this study) explores subjective experiences to understand the 'what', 'how' and 'why'.

	QUALITATIVE RESEARCH	QUANTITATIVE RESEARCH
Best for learning	-What do users...? -How do users...? -Why do users...?	-How many users...? -How much...?
Sample Size	-10 to 15 users	-100s and 1000s of users
Statistical significance	-No	-Yes

Sample Size in Qualitative Research

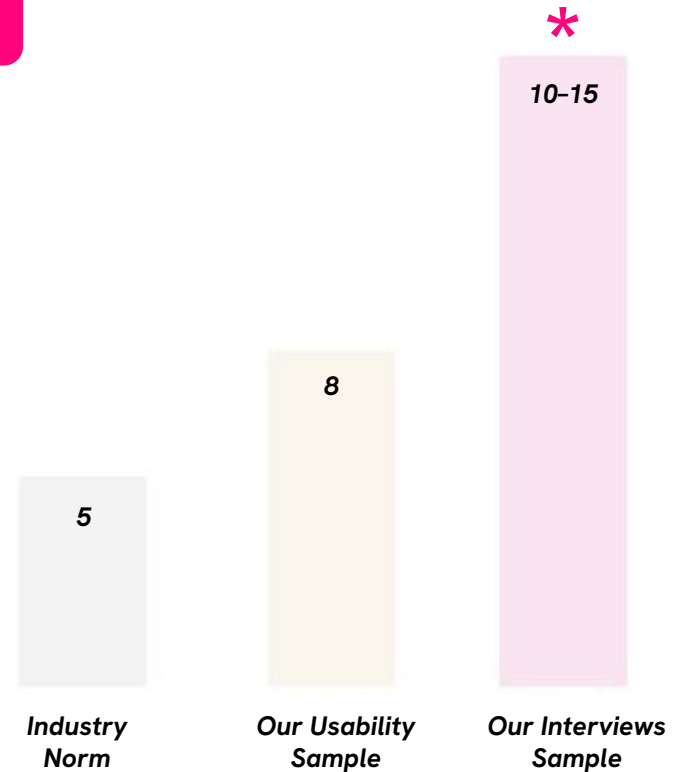
The industry norm for a usability test is to start with 5 participants.

However since our cohorts at Axis are often complex, we observe that we should start with 8 participants.

In the case of interviews, we observe that findings start getting saturated/ repetitive after 10-15 participants.

Qualitative Studies ≠ How Many

Reference: Nielsen Norman Group



User Profile and methodology

- 30–45 minute in depth interviews
- Participants recruited based on convenience sampling (i.e. whoever was available through colleagues, friends, family members)
- None of the participants were Axis users

S. No.	Age Group	Location	Tier
1	60–70	Mumbai	Tier 1
2	60–70	Jaipur	Tier 2
3	71–80	Hyderabad	Tier 1
4	60–70	Mumbai	Tier 1
5	60–70	Mumbai	Tier 1
6	71–80	Lakhna (Itawa, UP)	Tier 3
7	60–70	Jabalpur	Tier 2
8	60–70	Trivandrum	Tier 2
9	71–80	Hyderabad	Tier 1
10	60–70	Haryana	Tier 2
11	60–70	Hyderabad, Delhi, Chandigarh	Tier 1
12	71–80	Chandigarh	Tier 1
13	71–80	Chandigarh	Tier 1
14	80+	Siddipet	Tier 2
15	60–70	Bangalore	Tier 1

Research Goal

Understand the banking experience of senior citizens (60+),

1. Identify seniors' needs, behaviours, motivations, pain points, and expectations with banking.
2. Understand assistance & dependency patterns, including roles of caregivers, family, branch staff, and others in managing finances.
3. Understand digital literacy and tech comfort.
4. Understand trust and safety factors that influence their banking.

Tech Usage

Tech Usage (1/3)

Comfort with mobile usage

- **High** comfort indicates that participants **can manage using multiple apps** by themselves. They are also **comfortable exploring new apps** / features by themselves with **minimal assistance** .
- **Medium** comfort indicates they are most **comfortable performing basic or routine tasks** on it and **need assistance for unfamiliar interactions**.

"Youtube Whatsapp both are very easy. I'm using it to watch and not as a youtuber, so it is easy. Google Pay is very convenient. Easy to operate because I'm using it continuously from so many years. So it is easy for me. Instead of using some other UPI apps.
- 64 year old, Jabalpur

Security methods

- While **biometrics** is often considered the **easiest to operate** , it is **not effective** and does not register for senior citizens **due to natural aging processes**.
- The next easy choice is using a PIN as **4 digits** are relatively **easy to remember** and familiar strings like dates/number plates can be used.

"face reading ya fingerprint ka kabhi kabhi match nahi hota hai toh khulta nahi hai"
- 67 year old, Mumbai

Tech Usage (2/3)

Input Preference

- **Typing** is a preferred input method due to its familiarity/ **habitual** usage.
- **Voice input** though **easy** for low dexterity, often **does not work well** with the Indian **accent** and **vernacular** languages/ names.

"Type hi karta hu, voice vala toh kabhi attak jaata hai kabhi kuch, kabhi use samajh nahi aata"

- 66 year old, Haryana

"Hindi k kuch words ye nahi pakad pata hai. Trading wale app me bhi agar main 'Infosys' bolu toh ye samajh nahi pata hai."

- 64 year old, Jaipur

App Usage

- In non-finance apps, **Whatsapp** and **YouTube** were the most used apps amongst participants followed by **dialling/ receiving phone call** as the most done activity on the phone.
- In finance related apps, **higher comfort** is seen with **UPI apps** like GPay, PhonePe and Paytm for daily transactions. **Bank apps** are installed but **comparatively lower comfort is seen in using them due to fear of fraud.**

Tech Usage (3/3)

What makes an app easy?

Familiarity & Consistency

- Familiarity from routine usage which reduces cognitive load and also creates predictable expectations about upcoming screens, actions, and controls.

Intuitiveness & accessibility

- Interfaces that are simple, minimal, easy to comprehend, and provide unbroken flow also reduces cognitive load.

What makes an app difficult?

New or frequent Changes

- UI changes after updates break routine understanding and participants need to relearn a certain task, which takes time. Participants have stopped installing new apps.

Cluttered UI

- Having too many buttons or small icons creates poor accessibility leading to misclicks due to issues like fat finger, hand tremors, and low vision.
- Too many steps or options also makes comprehension and navigation confusing.

A major fear is not knowing the consequences, and process of rectification, if mistakes happen.

**Assistance,
Trust, Safety**

Assistance

Trust and availability are the major factors that influence assistance-seeking behaviour. **Help is primarily sought for anything that is not part of their routine usage** like error messages, technical issues, or installing new apps.

Preference for Assistance

- In our sample, participants aged 60-70 tended to prefer learning independently, whereas those aged 70+ more often favored assisted learning.

Preference for Format of Assistance

- This preference was also observed to be directly related to their comfort using a mobile phone.
 - Those with **low comfort** , prefer being **assisted in-person as it is easy to learn and understand**. They mostly seek assistance from immediate family (young). If they are not available they reach out to **people they trust** like their neighbours, and friends.
 - Those with **high comfort** prefer learning **by themselves** with the aid of **videos** as the **asynchronicity is convenient** . They are also already habituated to using Youtube for learning new information.

"My daughter is a computer engineer. So she helps me with everything. I video call and ask her any doubts and she does it for me."

- 65 year old, Mumbai

"I recently, visited my children on Diwali. They taught me how to use Instagram so I can see their photos. But I forgot everything and found it very difficult"

- 73 year old, Chandigarh

Trust

Fear of fraud and fear of mistakes were the most **common concerns** related to banking. Participants **need relief from the stress** of banking **but still also want to remain in control** of their finances and decisions.

- **Familiarity and personal connection** adds to trust be it people (how they behave) or the processes or the name of the bank itself.
- Next, **being informed** (be it receiving instant updates or guidance) also builds trust.

Behaviour

- Participants tend to stick to their routine usage and fear mistakes if they need to perform new tasks or handle large amounts.
- Overall it is related to the fear and frustration that arises from lack of knowledge on how to re-correct any mistake or being kept uninformed by the system.

*"Kuch galat na ho jaye mere
saath, mai kuch galti se kharaab
na kar du, ye hi darr lagta hai"*
- 73 year old, Chandigarh

*"ATM se paisa nikla nahi but
debit ka message aa gaya..usko
check karne k liye bohot idhar
udhar call karne pade..koi sahi
se bata hi nahi raha tha.."*
- 64 year old, Jaipur

Safety

Familiarity leads to trust which influences 'safety'. In the context of banking:

- Trusted people like **children, grandchildren, neighbours** are indicators of safety and assurance.
- **Bank touchpoints like familiar staff, automated calls, or the branch itself** are also perceived as safe.

Behaviour

- The news, family, and friends are the primary source of knowledge about scams.
- In our sample
 - half of the participants have experienced a scam themselves like receiving fake calls on phone or Whatsapp, or theft when they handed over phone to seek aid.
 - All participants have stopped opening unknown messages or links due to high awareness about increasing frauds (even if it is from the bank).
 - They also do not trust calls from unknown numbers often ignoring them completely.

*"Bete se pooch leta hu, bacho ko
toh fir aata hi hai sab aajkal"*

- 63 year old, Haryana

*"I was counting money in bank
and was taking time. Someone
provided me help and later on
while going to deposit I realised
he took 10,000 from 70,000
note bundle."*

- 81 year old, Siddipet

*"Bank se call hai toh kya ho
gaya...Kuch important hoga toh
main branch jaake puch lunga.
But I don't talk on phone."*

- 67 year old, Mumbai

The Banking Experience

Managing Finances & Banking tasks

Preference to Manage Finances

- **Autonomy and safety** are the primary drivers for participants preferring to manage their finances by **themselves** .
- Those that choose to take assistance, like to **still remain the primary decision maker** and take help mostly for execution (filling forms, digital banking tasks, etc).

Visiting Branch

- Participants **go to the branch mainly when something must be done in-person** like FDs, life certificates, cash, or problems they don't trust online systems to handle.
- They prefer fewer visits overall, but when they do go, they expect the branch to feel helpful, easy, and human.

*"main capable hu na... mera
paisa kaha hai kidhar hai,
trading karna hai, kya karna
hai..toh sab main kar leta hu"*
- 67 year old, Mumbai

Banking Tasks

- In our sample,
 - Daily transactions were most frequent by using both UPI and cash and includes paying bills or daily needs like commute, groceries, etc.
 - Other activities were intermittent or need-based like withdrawing money, checking FDs, checking balance/ updating passbook
 - Netbanking was trusted by few and done only by participants that had high comfort with using apps.

Expectations from Branch

Participants say they want to feel special and valued. This comes from the **staff being proactive** and helpful, consequently **reducing their efforts** and stress.

- The **issue is** when no one explains what is needed to be done or what can be expected for a certain banking task and participants have to **wait around in confusion to figure out by themselves.**

Accessibility beyond apps

- Accessibility is **needed in physical spaces** like easier movement, better signage and information (especially for low vision), and biometric alternatives since fingerprints often do not work.

Branch Experiences

- In our sample, all participants had atleast one account with a nationalised bank.
 - Slow services and long wait times make the branch experience poor along with lazy, uncooperative, rude staff which is often experienced at nationalised banks.
 - Positive experiences at the branch are tied to helpful and caring staff. Seeing familiar faces is also crucial.

"Patience chahiye lekin, agar VIP branch bhi hai aur fir bhi agar log hain toh wait karna padta hai...Agar wait karne ke baad bhi, aapko jaisa expected tha unka good behaviour, exact jaisi currency chahiye, voh sab mill gaya toh aap khushi khushi ghar aate ho"

- 72 year old, Chandigarh

"kisi se puche bhi toh wo bas ishara kar denge idhar chale jao udhar chale jao..koi proper guide karne wala nahi hota hai ki kaha kis counter pe kya kaam ho raha hai"

- 64 year old, Jaipur

Doorstep Banking

Preferences for doorstep banking

- Those that **highly** preferred this mode liked it for its **convenience**.
- Those that were **okay** with it had **inhibitions** due to **lack of trust** in the person visiting them and **fear of fraud**.
- Those that were **not willing** for such a service feel it will make them **lazy** and they **prefer to remain active** as long as possible.

Willingness to pay for doorstep banking

- The willingness to pay for doorstep banking services is **not very high**.
 - Those that were willing **want to be charged nominally** on a per-service basis or a percentage like service charge or a one-time lump sum payment (to avoid hassle of paying everytime).
 - Overall, Rs 250/ year or Rs100/ visit is bearable **as most are pensioners or have unsteady income**.

*"bank tak chal k nahi ja paate hai, bacche bhi hamare paas nahi rehte, sab bahar rehte hai...kisi aur ko le jaenge toh wo hamara khaata number bank number sab dekh lega...toh accha hi hai agar koi ghar aaye...lekin ye sab tab jab bank ki taraf se mazboot suvidha hai tabhi..hume ID card ya photo dena chahiye ki ye insaan aaega aapke ghar..hum photocopy rakheneghe pehchan ne k liye...
- 72 year old, Lakhna*

*"I can walk and go, the bank is very near. I won't pay. In the future maybe one time payment.."
- 70 year old, Trivandrum*

Comparative Preferences (Banking Scenarios)

Rank by preference (not statistical)	Type of banking scenario	Pros	Cons
1	Taking help from a family member	Trust and safety with assistance from family, friends, branch staff.	Help might not always be readily available or answers might not be known by helper.
2	By themselves, using an app	Being self reliant is best as it assures autonomy and confidence that nothing will be tampered with	Lack of digital literacy and low comfort using phone
3	Visiting the branch	Least risk since it is a bank touchpoint	Inconvenient to go, wait as services are poor and staff is often lazy.
4	Doorstep Banking	Great choice only in cases of poor health or disability.	Might make them lazy and inactive.

"Main usme nikamma ho jaunga. Ghar se nikal nahi raha hu, logo ko pareshan kar raha hu..Bank walking distance hai toh main chala jata hu paidal..waise aaj kal to zyada jana bhi nahi hoto qki netbanking hai, paas me ATM bhi hai...thoda haath paun chalte rahenge"

- 64 year old, Jaipur



Thank You

Research Report

Senior Citizen Banking

Phase 2: Branch Visits



by **Rhитуja Shende, Saad Ahmed, Sandeep Kumar**

Research Goal, User Profile, and Methodology

Since branch staff often interact with senior citizens, we aimed to understand senior citizens' banking through staff's experience.

6 employees were interviewed across 6 branches in Tier 1 cities.

S. No.	Designation	Location	Tier
1	Branch Head	Hyderabad	Tier 1
2	Branch Head	Hyderabad	Tier 1
3	BRO	Thane	Tier 1
4	Assistant Manager	Mumbai	Tier 1
5	BRO DM	Mumbai	Tier 1
6	Senior Manager	Mumbai	Tier 1

Branch Visit Behaviours

- Senior citizens usually walk-in to the branch. They visit 1-2 times a month and spend around 10-30 mins at the branch.
- Users who live near branches prefer to visit it, especially since they have more free time.
 - If family members live away, branch staff are the next POCs that are reliable and accessible in-person.
 - The branch not only helps them satisfy their enquiries but it also is a space for light chitchat.

"They're used to visiting the branch now...some have very good relation, they sometime come here have coffee, complete the task and go home. Some spend good amount of time chit chatting if they are free."

- Branch Head, Hyderabad



10-20% branch visitors are senior citizens

STAFF OBSERVATIONS
(NOT STATISTICAL)

Branch Visit Motivations

While banking needs is a obvious reason for branch visits, the underlying motivation is that **execution of the banking tasks** (which can be complicated for senior citizens) **gets offloaded to the staff. The user still remains the decision maker but all the operational work is done by a trusted person.**

Branch visits for banking needs

- **Category 1: Tasks that can only be done at the branch**
 - Updating and printing the Passbook, Procuring DDs
- **Category 2: Tasks that can be done via digital banking**
 - Procuring account statement, Managing FDs, Transferring money via RTGS/ NEFT, Procuring Life Certificate
- **Category 3: When users face issues with mobile banking app**
 - Product Issues where features/ items are not visible
 - Lack of clear info on limitations of features
 - Issues with documentation

"In case the customer defaults, their credit card is blocked. The card itself is not visible in the app. Now how will they pay the bill or charges?"

- Branch Head, Hyderabad

Barriers to Assisted Digital Adoption

While the staff regularly pushes for digital adoption, there's reluctance to use app due to fear of mistake and frauds.

Verbal reassurance , even from a trusted person like branch staff, **is not enough** . Using **mobile banking** requires users to perform tasks themselves which they often find complex. **There is no possibility to offload operations compared to branch assistance.**

"Arey madam kon app khol kar dhundega. Roz roz thodi cheque book lagta hai...Aapne toh bata diya, magar yaad kidhar rahega wo baad me? App me itna sara cheez rehta hai, kidhar dhundega. Usse achca idhar aake chale jata hu, dekh bhi lunga apna bank"

– BRO, Thane

Other barriers

- When RMs aid registration on mobile banking app, users might not have an email to receive the OTP.
- A one time explanation/ walkthrough may not be enough if a function involves more than 4-5 steps.
- Remotely resolving issues is difficult as the staff might not be able to grasp the problem and explain solution properly. Hence staff often asks users to visit branch. They are able to guide them better in-person and it also reduces the need for senior users to share personal information over phone call.



Thank You

Below: For Product team
(Sameer's deck)

Senior Citizen Banking: Qualitative Research*

Objectives of the study

Understand

1. Needs, behaviours, motivations, pain points, and expectations with banking.
2. Assistance & dependency patterns, including roles of caregivers, family, branch staff, and others in managing finances.
3. Digital literacy and tech comfort.
4. Trust and safety factors that influence their banking.

Methodology used for the study

25 in-depth interviews

1. (30–45 min each) were conducted with 19 senior citizens and 6 branch staff across Tier 1 & 2 cities.
2. Participants were recruited based on convenience sampling (i.e. whoever was available through colleagues, friends, family members)
3. None of the participants were Axis Bank users

**Qualitative research (like this study) explores subjective experiences to understand the 'what', 'how' and 'why' instead of 'how many'.*

Tech Experience

What makes an app easy?

Familiarity & Consistency

- Familiarity from routine usage which reduces cognitive load and also creates predictable expectations about upcoming screens, actions, and controls.
Ex. higher comfort is seen with typing, or using Whatsapp & Youtube due to routine and long term usage

Intuitiveness & accessibility

- Interfaces that are simple, minimal, easy to comprehend, and provide unbroken flow also reduces cognitive load.

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"Kuch galat na ho jaye mere saath, mai kuch galti se kharaab na kar du, ye hi darr lagta hai"

- 73 year old, Chandigarh

Overall, an underlying fear to digital adoption or exploration is uncertainty about what might go wrong and assuming recovery will be difficult/ complex.

"ATM se paisa nikla nahi but debit ka message aa gaya..usko check karne k liye bohot idhar udhar call karne pade..koi sahi se bata hi nahi raha tha.."

- 64 year old, Jaipur

Trust, Safety, and Assistance

1. Familiarity slowly builds trust which then creates a sense of safety.

- a. Trusted people (family, neighbours) and bank touchpoints (familiar staff, the branch itself) are indicators of safety and assurance.
- b. Familiarity, personal connection, and feeling informed (be it receiving instant updates or guidance) also builds trust

2. Assistance is sought only from these trusted sources and specifically for offloading execution/ operational work.

- a. Participants need relief from the stress of banking but want to remain in control of their finances and decisions.
- b. While the staff regularly pushes for digital adoption, verbal reassurance is not enough. Using mobile banking requires users to perform tasks themselves which they often find complex. There is lower possibility to offload operations compared to branch assistance.

"My daughter is a computer engineer. So she helps me with everything. I video call and ask her any doubts and she does it for me."
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- BRO, Thane

Expectations from the Branch

1. Autonomy and safety are the primary drivers for participants preferring to manage their finances by themselves.

- a. Participants go to the branch mainly when something must be done in-person like FDs, life certificates, cash, or problems they don't trust online systems to handle.

2. Participants say they want to feel special and valued.

- a. This comes from the staff being proactive and helpful, consequently reducing their efforts and stress.

3. Accessibility beyond apps

- a. Accessibility is needed in physical spaces like easier movement, better signage and information (especially for low vision), and biometric alternatives since fingerprints often do not work.



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